‘I will ask the referee to allow Gunjan to start from inside the pool,’ Maa said.

‘No,’ Dada and I said in unison. ‘You won’t do any such thing.’

Just like any other teenager, I did not want my parents to stand up for me.

‘Whatever you do, just give it your best shot,’ Papaji said, putting an end to the conversation.

The officers’ mess inside the Babina cantonment was readied according to the ceremonial layout. Flags were placed at the entrance and a red carpet was laid down; it went up till the chief guest’s chair. Two lancers, dressed in the Sikh regimental outfit, stood guard at the main door to welcome the chief guest, who was the station commander’s wife. The competition was scheduled to begin at ten in the morning. Officers, their wives and children, including participants, started trickling in almost an hour earlier. Maa accompanied me and Dada and wished us luck before she went to her seat in the audience section. The referee whistled for the lifeguards to take their positions. The timekeepers occupied their seats as Dada and I walked towards the changing room. I was to go first.

‘Remember, just dive,’ Dada held me by my shoulders and firmly said. I nodded and went to the changing room. The chief guest arrived at quarter to ten. The first round was to be held among women under eighteen. We lined up at our respective starting points at the edge of the swimming pool. I looked around, to my left and right, and saw my competitors prepare for a dive. I could feel butterflies in my stomach. For a moment, it felt like the entire crowd was looking only at me. It added to my nervousness. People would laugh at me if I jumped instead of dived, I thought. My gaze found Dada’s, standing at the other end of the pool with his friends, nodding slightly to remind me that I should not jump. The referee then asked us to take the final position. I could see Dada turn his back towards me and cover his eyes with his hands. The referee blew the whistle and even though I tried to dive, I ended up jumping into the pool while every other competitor floated ahead of me after their successful dives. For a moment, I struggled to pace up. It was a moment of realization and I understood I was going to fail. But something inside me was just not ready to give up yet. So I closed